



Tips & Tricks



Solve an X/display issue in VLC

Do you ever face problems opening VLC in Fedora (or for that matter, in any other distro)? You might have often come across errors like, "Could not connect to X server," or "Could not open display." VLC won't run as the root. A simple solution is to disable xServer access control. Type the following command to achieve this (you need to be the root user to execute this):

```
xhost +
```

Now you can go back to being a non-root user and run VLC player.

— Purna Chander,

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Using 'or' in grep

grep is a wonderful tool that helps you search for a particular word, or words, in files. So, how do we use the 'or' operator in grep (for example, if we want grep to look for either 'www' or 'server' when searching)? Issue the following command:

```
grep 'www\|server' /etc/httpd/conf/httpd.conf
```

— Remin Raphael, remin13@gmail.com



Inserting sudo insults for when a wrong password is entered

Edit the `/etc/sudoers` file:

```
sudo visudo
```

Add insults in the line that begins with "Defaults", which should look like what follows:

```
Defaults      insults
```

Save the file. Now, whenever you type your sudo password wrong, sudo will insult you with a random phrase. Go ahead and check it out; it could be fun.

— Bhuvanesh Kumar, bhuvibhuvanesh@gmail.com



When to use xargs

If a command is expecting arguments instead of standard input, then piping will fail (i.e., `cmd1 | cmd2` may not work). In such cases, `xargs` will be helpful. It supplies standard input as arguments to a given command (the command itself is passed as an argument to `xargs`):

```
cmd1 | xargs cmd2 works fine
```

For example:

```
find <location> -name <filepattern> | xargs grep <searchpattern>
```

```
...OR:
```

```
find <location> -name <filepattern> | xargs rm -f
```

— Rajesh Sola, rajesh@lisor.org



Find out the time taken for a command's execution

You can use the `time` command to find out the actual time that elapses between the invocation and termination of a command, the CPU time used by the command in user mode, and the CPU time used by the command in system mode. For example, here is the output of `ps`, timed by using the `time` command:

```
$ time ps
PID TTY          TIME CMD
7795 pts/2    00:00:00 bash
8868 pts/2    00:00:00 ps
real    0m0.003s
```